THE HOME LINE

The First 30 Days

After a death, if nothing is in place

What has to happen now, what can safely wait a month, and the mistakes that are hard to undo.

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You do not have to read all of this today.

We are sorry. Someone you love has died, and you have been handed a list of things to do with no sense of which ones are urgent.

Most of them are not. Almost everything people will tell you about in the next few weeks can wait a month without any harm at all. A small number of things cannot, and those are on the next page.

If you read only one section, read the one called What not to do. The mistakes that are hard to undo are made in the first few weeks, usually by someone trying to be helpful.

FOUR THINGS, AND THEN YOU CAN STOP

1. Order the death certificates.
2. Tell three people and let them help.
3. Do not close anything or sign anything.
4. Look for the documents: a will, a trust, life insurance policies, recent bank and retirement statements, and a One Page if they made one. If you cannot find them, that is a solvable problem, and the section called If you cannot find anything explains how.

Everything else in this guide is a nice-to-have in the first week.

IF YOU ARE THE ONE WHO NEVER HANDLED THE MONEY

That is more common than anyone says out loud, and it is not something to be embarrassed about now. You do not need to learn personal finance this month. You need to know three things: (1) what comes in, (2) what goes out, and (3) who to call.

Find one person you trust to sit beside you for the next year. A grown child, a sibling, a friend who is good with this. Not to take over and not to decide for you, just so you are not reading statements alone at the kitchen table at eleven at night.

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RIGHT NOW

The first 48 hours

WHY THIS MATTERS These four keep everything else possible. Certificates unlock every account, helpers keep you from carrying it alone, and not signing anything protects choices you cannot undo later.

Four things. Nothing on this page involves a decision about money.

- [ ] **Order certified death certificates. Order more than feels reasonable.**

  Most families need ten to twelve. Every bank, insurer, retirement plan and title office wants its own certified copy, and ordering a second batch later costs weeks. The funeral home usually handles this. Ask for the extras now.

- [ ] **Tell three people, and let them do things.**

  People want a job. Give them one: meals, the phone, the dog, driving. You do not have to be gracious about it and you do not have to be in charge.

- [ ] **Do not close, cancel, move or sign anything.**

  Not accounts, not cards, not subscriptions, not the car. None of it is urgent and some of it is hard to reverse. This includes anything a well-meaning relative suggests.

- [ ] **Look for the documents, and do not panic if they are not there.**

  A will, a trust, insurance policies, a one page if they made one. Check the safe, the filing cabinet, the desk, the safe deposit box, and the email. If you come up empty, the section called If you cannot find anything is written for exactly that.

ABOUT SOCIAL SECURITY

The funeral home usually reports the death for you. Here is how to make sure it happened.

1. Ask the funeral director whether they reported the death to Social Security. Write down the date they did.
2. If they did not, or you are not sure, call Social Security at 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778), weekdays 8 a.m. to 7 p.m. local time, or visit your local office. Have their Social Security number ready.
3. If a benefit arrives for the month of death, do not spend it. It usually has to be returned, which is normal and not a sign anyone did anything wrong.

Survivor benefits, and a one-time $255 death payment for a qualifying spouse or child, are a separate application. They cannot be applied for online, and they are not urgent this week. The rest of the month section covers them.

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DAYS 3 TO 7

The first week

WHY THIS MATTERS These calls start the money that keeps the household running, and protect the insurance and coverage that can quietly lapse in the first weeks.

Phone calls, mostly. None of these require you to decide anything.

- [ ] **Call an estate attorney, even if you think there is nothing to probate.**

  A thirty-minute call tells you whether you need probate at all, what is already handled by beneficiary designations, and what order to do things in. If you do not have one, call any estate attorney in your state and say that someone in your family has died and you do not know where to start.

- [ ] **Call the employer, if they were working.**

  Ask about final pay, unused vacation, life insurance through work, the retirement plan, and how long any family health coverage lasts. Employer life insurance is the policy families most often forget exists.

- [ ] **Start the life insurance claims.**

  Call each carrier, ask what they need, and send it. Most claims pay in a few weeks once the paperwork is in. This is usually the fastest money available to you and it does not go through probate.

- [ ] **Keep collecting and opening their mail.**

  For the next three months the mail is how you discover accounts, policies and bills nobody told you about. Open all of it, even the junk. If they lived somewhere else, have their mail forwarded to you through the post office so none of it is lost.

- [ ] **If there is a business, find out what happens Monday.**

  Who runs it, whether payroll is covered, and who has access to the accounts. You do not have to make decisions. You have to know who is keeping it alive this week.

- [ ] **Make sure the house and the cars are still insured.**

  A policy in their name alone can lapse or be contested after a death. One call to the agent settles it.

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WEEKS 2 TO 4

The rest of the month

WHY THIS MATTERS Some of these have deadlines, and one wrong move with a retirement account can cost thousands. Gathering first means every later decision is made with the full picture.

Still no big decisions. This is gathering, not deciding.

- [ ] **Apply for Social Security survivor benefits.**

  Call 1-800-772-1213 or visit your local office. You cannot apply online. Bring the death certificate, both Social Security numbers, and your marriage certificate if you were married. Ask about the one-time $255 death payment, and about when to claim, because claiming early can permanently reduce the amount.

- [ ] **Contact the retirement plans and the IRA custodians.**

  A surviving spouse usually has options nobody else gets, and some are one-time elections. Do not move or cash out anything until you have talked to the attorney or a tax advisor. This is the single most expensive thing to get wrong.

- [ ] **Sort out health insurance.**

  If you were covered through their employer, find out when it ends and what the options are. Mark the deadline on a calendar the day you learn it.

- [ ] **Notify the credit bureaus.**

  Report the death to Equifax, Experian and TransUnion so the file is flagged. It prevents a very ugly kind of identity theft that targets the recently deceased.

- [ ] **Make a list of every account you have found so far.**

  Not organized, not complete. Just a running list on one page. This becomes your version of the one page, and it will be the most useful thing you own for the next year.

- [ ] **Ask the attorney whether probate is required at all.**

  Many estates do not need it, or qualify for a simplified process. Finding out costs one phone call and can save months.

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READ THIS ONE

What not to do

These are the decisions that are hard or impossible to reverse.

- ☐ **Do not close the joint accounts.**
  They are usually the money you can reach most easily right now. Closing one can leave you waiting on probate for cash you already had.

- ☐ **Do not cash out, roll over or move a retirement account before you have advice.**
  A surviving spouse has options nobody else has, and for anyone inheriting, a wrong move can create a tax bill in the tens of thousands that cannot be undone.

- ☐ **Do not sell the house, and do not promise it to anyone.**
  There is no deadline. There are also tax consequences to the timing that are worth one conversation before you act.

- ☐ **Do not make large gifts to children or family.**
  Not even the ones you intend to make eventually. Do them after the estate is settled, with advice, so you do not give away something you later need.

- ☐ **Do not take financial advice from anyone who contacted you first.**
  Deaths are public record. People will call. A person who found you this way is selling something, however kind they sound.

- ☐ **Do not sign anything you do not understand.**
  Including anything handed to you at the bank, by an insurance agent, or by a relative. It is always acceptable to say you will have someone look at it.

- ☐ **Do not let anyone rush a decision about the business.**
  Partners, buyers and key employees may all have reasons to move quickly. A business is rarely worth less in sixty days, and your leverage is highest before you agree to anything.

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THE HARDEST VERSION

If you cannot find anything

No will, no list, no passwords. This happens often, and there is a path.

You are not going to reconstruct this in a week, and you do not need to. These six moves find most of what exists, in roughly this order.

- ☐ **Pull a credit report in their name.**
  This is the single most useful document available to you. It lists nearly every open account, card, loan and line of credit. Free at annualcreditreport.com, which is the official site.

- ☐ **Get the last two years of tax returns.**
  They show employers, interest from accounts you did not know about, dividends, business income and property. If you cannot find copies, the CPA has them, and the IRS can provide a transcript.

- ☐ **Read twelve months of bank and card statements line by line.**
  Every insurance premium, every subscription, every loan payment is in there. Highlight anything that repeats. That list is the start of your account inventory.

- ☐ **Keep opening the mail for ninety days.**
  Annual statements, premium notices and tax documents arrive on their own schedule. The ones that come in February will tell you things the ones in October did not.

- ☐ **Use the NAIC life policy locator for insurance you cannot find.**
  A free service that asks participating insurers to search their records for policies naming the person who died. It takes time but it costs nothing and it finds policies families had given up on.

- ☐ **Search your state's unclaimed property database.**
  Old accounts, uncashed checks and forgotten policies end up with the state. Search every state they lived in, not just this one.

THIS GETS BETTER

Everyone who has done this describes the same thing: the first month feels like it will never end, and then one day the picture is mostly assembled and the fear goes out of it. You are not behind. There is no schedule you are failing to meet.

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Who to notify, and when

Roughly in order. Nothing in the third column is a hard legal deadline unless your attorney says otherwise for your situation.

WHO	WHY	WHEN
Social Security	Stop payments, apply for survivor benefits	First week, benefits later
The employer	Final pay, group life, retirement plan, health coverage	First week
Life insurance carriers	Start the claim. Usually the fastest money	First week
The estate attorney	Find out whether probate is needed at all	First week
Banks and credit unions	Notify, do not close. Ask what you can access now	Week two
Retirement and IRA custodians	Spousal options and elections	Week two, with advice
Health, home and auto insurers	Keep coverage in force, change the named insured	Week two
The three credit bureaus	Flag the file against identity theft	Weeks two to four
Pension or annuity providers	Survivor elections, which can be one-time	Weeks two to four
The CPA	Final tax return, and what the estate will owe	Within a few months
Mortgage and lenders	Keep paying. Ask about assumption rights	Within a few months
DMV, utilities, subscriptions	Retitling and cleanup	No rush at all

KEEP A CALL LOG

One notebook. Date, who you called, what they said, and what they need from you. You will be asked the same questions by a dozen organizations, and three months from now you will not remember which one already has the death certificate. This one habit saves more time than any app.

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One more thing

At some point in the next year, someone you know will be where you are now. You will be the person who understands what this takes.

When that happens, the most useful thing you can give them is not advice. It is this: tell them which four things mattered in the first week, and then offer to sit with them while they make the calls. That is what almost nobody gets, and it is the thing that makes the difference.

IF YOU WANT HELP

Jeppson Law practices in California and Utah. If you are somewhere else, call any estate attorney in your state and tell them that someone in your family has died and you do not know where to start. That is a complete and reasonable opening sentence and they hear it often.

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This is educational material, not legal advice, and reading it does not create an attorney-client relationship. Probate, property and benefit rules differ by state, and a few of the steps here have deadlines that vary. Jeppson Law practices in California and Utah. Talk to a licensed attorney in your state before acting on anything in this guide.

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